# THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER TWELVE

## “EARTH'S MIGHTIEST”

June 15 – August 9, 2010
New York • View Park • Beverly Hills • San Diego

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

**FADE IN:**

**INT. THE CHERRY LANE THEATRE - BACKSTAGE - GREENWICH VILLAGE, NEW YORK CITY - NIGHT**

**SUPER: TUESDAY, JUNE 15, 2010 - 10:40 P.M. EDT**

A tiny, historic Off-Broadway house. Exposed brick, a single cramped dressing room shared by five actors. ARIANNA CUMMINGS (27) sits at a mirror lined with bare bulbs, wiping off stage makeup. Taped to the mirror: a NEW YORK TIMES review ("Arianna Cummings is the best actress in New York that nobody has heard of"), a photo of her grandmother, and four rejection notes from her agent, each crossed out in red Sharpie.

Her cell rings. A 310 number. She almost ignores it.

ARIANNA
(answering, tired)
Hello?

FEIGE (V.O.)
Arianna? It's Kevin Feige, from Marvel. I have Joss Whedon here with me. Do you have a minute?

Arianna sits up straight. The other actors in the room stop talking.

WHEDON (V.O.)
Hi, Arianna. Joss. I've watched your Hawkeye test about thirty times. The archery range one. When you hit the bullseye and then shot the arrow already in the bullseye? Splitting it?

ARIANNA
(carefully)
The trainer said I couldn't do that. I'd been practicing for six weeks.

WHEDON (V.O.)
You did it on the first take. And then you looked at the camera like you were bored. That's Claire Barton. Carnival kid. Trick shooter. Smartest mouth in S.H.I.E.L.D. The best at what she does and nobody ever gives her credit.

Arianna's hand drifts to the four crossed-out rejection notes on the mirror.

FEIGE (V.O.)
We'd like you to be Hawkeye.

A long silence. The other actors in the dressing room hold their breath.

ARIANNA
(very quietly)
Mr. Feige. I've been told "you were amazing, we went another way" four times in two years. I need you to say it again. Slowly.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Arianna Cummings. You are Claire Barton. You are Hawkeye. We're revealing you on stage in Hall H on July twenty-fourth, and until then, you can't tell a soul.

Arianna looks around the dressing room at four other actors, frozen and staring at her.

ARIANNA
...I'm in a dressing room with four people, Kevin.

WHEDON (V.O.)
(laughing)
Then make them sign something.

She hangs up. Turns to the four actors. Takes a deep breath.

ARIANNA
Nobody saw anything.

The OLDEST ACTOR (60s) in the room slowly stands up and starts to applaud. The others join in. Arianna buries her face in her hands and laughs until she cries. Then she takes the red Sharpie and draws a big check mark across all four crossed-out rejection notes.

CUT TO:

**INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - CELESTE'S DRESSING ROOM - VIEW PARK - NIGHT**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 3, 2010 - 10:15 P.M. PDT**

A soft, elegant room: a vanity, perfume bottles, framed magazine covers of a young CELESTE ARRINGTON from her Ebony Fashion Fair days. CELESTE SMILLEY (50) sits at the vanity removing her earrings. In the mirror, she sees ESTHER (27) standing in the doorway, holding a laptop.

CELESTE
Baby. It's late.

ESTHER
You said I could tell you. You said "not today, but soon." It's soon, Mama.

Celeste turns around. Esther closes the door behind her. She sits on the edge of the bed and opens the laptop. She plugs in an SD card. A folder opens: twelve photographs.

Children's Hospital. Paper crowns. Esther and Marc-Anthony on the floor with sick kids, laughing. A little girl with a headscarf in a gold paper crown.

Celeste looks at the screen for a very long time. Esther watches her mother's face. Waiting.

CELESTE
(finally, very quietly)
Who took these?

ESTHER
A man Daddy hired to follow me. Two years ago. He lied to Daddy and said he saw nothing. He mailed them to me on Mother's Day.

Celeste closes her eyes.

CELESTE
Your father had you followed.

ESTHER
First Simone. Then me.

A long beat. Celeste opens her eyes and looks at the screen again. At her daughter's face in the photo. At the laugh.

CELESTE
How long?

ESTHER
Since the Kids' Choice Awards. We were eleven. We've been friends my whole life, Mama. Every day. Secretly. And since...

(her voice breaking slightly)
Since about four years ago it's been more than friends. For me. Nothing's ever happened. Not once. I wouldn't let it. Because of Daddy. Because of the Oath. Because of all of it.

Celeste stands. Walks to the window. Looks out at the dark garden. When she speaks, her voice is steady but strange.

CELESTE
Do you know how I met your father?

ESTHER
At the Ebony Fashion Fair. In Chicago. He was in the audience.

CELESTE
That's the story we tell. The truth is, I was engaged to someone else. A dentist from Hyde Park. Kind man. Boring man. My mother picked him. My father approved of him. Everybody approved of him. And then a beautiful, angry, brilliant young actor walked backstage after the show and told me I was the most elegant woman he had ever seen.

(beat)
My mother didn't speak to me for a year after I married Desmond Smilley.

Esther stares at her mother. She's never heard any of this.

ESTHER
I didn't know.

CELESTE
Nobody knows. Your father doesn't like to remember that he wasn't anybody's first choice either.

She turns back to her daughter. Her eyes are wet, but her face is set.

CELESTE (CONT'D)
Listen to me very carefully. Your father must never see these photographs.

ESTHER
He already knows, Mama. The rooftop. TMZ.

CELESTE
He suspects. Suspecting and seeing are different things. A man can argue with a suspicion. He can't argue with a little girl in a paper crown.

(sitting beside Esther, taking her hands)
I can't stand up to your father the way Simone does. Or your grandfather. I don't know how. I never learned. But I will not help him stop you. Do you understand me? I will not help him.

ESTHER
(tears falling)
Mama...

CELESTE
And I want to meet him. The Bullock boy. Properly. Someday.

(a small, watery smile)
I want to see if he's as handsome as he is in the paper-crown pictures.

CUT TO:

**INT. THE BEVERLY HILLS HOTEL - POLO LOUNGE - DAY**

**SUPER: THURSDAY, JULY 15, 2010 - 3:00 P.M. PDT**

The legendary pink-and-green dining room. Banana-leaf wallpaper. Agents and executives at every booth, pretending not to watch the corner booth.

Because in the corner booth sits NATASHA BULLOCK (49), in a white suit, sipping an iced tea. And across from her, in a navy suit, DESMOND SMILLEY (52).

Two heads of two dynasties. The first time they've sat at the same table in more than twenty years. Every head in the room is turned slightly toward them.

DESMOND
Thank you for coming.

NATASHA
You asked. Thirty years of silence, and then a voicemail at my office. "Natasha, it's Desmond. We need to talk about our children." How could I not come?

DESMOND
Then I'll be direct. Keep your son away from my daughter.

Natasha sets down her iced tea.

NATASHA
I can't keep my son anywhere, Desmond. He's twenty-eight years old. He's Iron Man. He's the most famous actor in the world.

DESMOND
You run the largest company on Earth. You can do anything you want.

NATASHA
And you think I want to stop my son from loving someone?

A beat. Desmond's jaw tightens at the word.

DESMOND
Loving. So you admit it.

NATASHA
I admit what I saw on Mother's Day, in the Sunday paper, and on my son's face. And in Hall H last year, when she lifted that hammer and he jumped out of his chair like a child. And at the Iron Man 2 premiere, when he turned around in his seat to find her in the dark.

(beat)
Desmond. I've watched my son grow up in front of cameras since he was five years old. I've never once seen him look at anything the way he looks at your daughter.

DESMOND
(leaning forward, quiet and fierce)
Your father took my grandfather's money. Your father took my father's company. Your husband called me a frame with no painting in it in a national magazine. Your company stole my clients. And now your son wants my daughter?

NATASHA
My son doesn't "want" anybody. Esther Smilley is a grown woman who lifted a fifteen-pound hammer over her head in front of six thousand people. She doesn't belong to you, and she doesn't belong to him.

Desmond sits back. He looks at her for a long moment.

DESMOND
You're enjoying this.

NATASHA
I'm not enjoying anything, Desmond. Do you know what I've watched my whole life? I've watched my father look at a telephone. For forty-three years. Every Christmas. Every birthday. Every time something good happened, I'd see his hand drift toward the phone, and then stop.

(beat)
Do you know your father called mine on election night?

Desmond freezes completely.

DESMOND
...What?

NATASHA
November fourth, 2008. A few minutes after eight o'clock. The private line in my father's study rang once. The caller ID said "SMILLEY C." And then it stopped. Your father hung up before mine could answer.

(beat)
My mother told me. My father hasn't slept through a full night since.

Desmond stares at her. For the first time in the conversation, his composure cracks. Something passes across his face: confusion, then pain, then something that looks almost like grief.

DESMOND
(barely audible)
He never told me.

NATASHA
Of course he didn't. He's a proud man. So is mine. And they've wasted forty-three years of their lives being proud.

(leaning forward, softer)
I'm not going to let my son waste his. And if you have any sense, Desmond, you won't let your daughter waste hers.

She stands, dropping a hundred-dollar bill on the table for an iced tea she barely touched.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
The tea's on me. Consider it a Donohue tradition.

She walks out. Every eye in the Polo Lounge follows her. Desmond sits alone in the booth, staring at the table, his hand flat against the tablecloth.

A WAITER (60s), who has worked there since 1971, approaches cautiously.

WAITER
Can I get you anything else, Mr. Smilley?

DESMOND
(not looking up)
No. Thank you, Ernesto.

The waiter hesitates. Then, quietly:

WAITER
Your father used to sit in this booth with Mr. Donohue. Every Friday. In 1965. They'd laugh so loud the manager had to ask them to keep it down.

Desmond looks up at him, stunned. The waiter just nods and moves away.

CUT TO:

**EXT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H LINE - NIGHT**

**SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 23, 2010 - 11:30 P.M. PDT**

The fourth annual reunion of "THE WORTHY" under their canopy. GARY (44), PRIYA (25), DARNELL (32), and TOMMY (22). They now have a banner made by a professional printer, folding chairs with their usernames embroidered on them, and a battery-powered espresso machine.

TOMMY
Tomorrow is the Avengers. It's happening. They're going to bring out the whole cast.

GARY
We know the cast. Iron Man, Hulk, Ant-Man, Wasp, Thor, Cap. The founders. Avengers #1, plus Cap from #4. Done.

PRIYA
Harmony Divine's Black Widow is in the movie too. She was in Iron Man 2. And somebody has to be Hawkeye. There are rumors everywhere.

DARNELL
Hawkeye's not a founder. Hawkeye joins in #16. "Cap's Kooky Quartet." With Quicksilver and the Scarlet Witch.

PRIYA
(slowly, eyes widening)
...Which means if they cast Hawkeye now, they're planning the Kooky Quartet. They're planning the movie AFTER the Avengers.

Everybody goes quiet.

GARY
Priya. Priya. We haven't even seen the first Avengers movie yet.

PRIYA
Marvel always plants things early. The Wasp was in Iron Man two years before Ant-Man. The hammer was in Iron Man 2 a year before Thor. If Hawkeye's in the Avengers...

TOMMY
...then the second Avengers is already planned.

DARNELL
(raising his espresso)
To Hall H.

ALL FOUR
To Hall H.

CUT TO:

**INT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - AMOND'S ROOM - NIGHT**

**SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 23, 2010 - 11:55 P.M. PDT**

AMOND BAKER (28) lies on the bed staring at the ceiling. MARC-ANTHONY (28) sits in the desk chair, feet up, eating room service fries.

AMOND
She keeps saying "friends."

MARC-ANTHONY
Harmony?

AMOND
Three years. Grant Park. Comic-Con. Premieres. Every press article says "rumored couple." And every single time somebody asks her, she says "Amond's my friend." She says it like a contract. Like she's been told to say it by a lawyer.

MARC-ANTHONY
Have you asked her why?

AMOND
(sitting up)
I asked her once. At the Iron Man 2 afterparty. She said, "Ask me when my knee stops hurting."

MARC-ANTHONY
Her knee? The 2005 injury?

AMOND
She tore her ACL in the middle of a show. Lost Broadway. Lost everything. She told me she spent a year on a couch in Queens thinking she'd never dance again. She said the only thing that saved her was not needing anybody.

(beat)
I think she thinks if she needs me, she'll lose me. Like she lost the dancing.

Marc-Anthony puts down the fries.

MARC-ANTHONY
Then don't push. Just stay.

AMOND
How long?

MARC-ANTHONY
As long as it takes. That's what the porch is for, Mond.

Amond looks at his best friend. Then, slowly, he smiles.

AMOND
You're one to talk. How long have you been staying for "Pastor Williams"?

MARC-ANTHONY
(a long pause)
Twenty years if you count the pencil.

AMOND
And?

MARC-ANTHONY
She said "ask me again in London."

AMOND
(lying back down, grinning at the ceiling)
We're both idiots.

MARC-ANTHONY
Hulk smart. Hulk patient.

CUT TO:

**INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H - DAY**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010 - 3:00 P.M. PDT**

Six thousand five hundred people. The loudest room in America. On the giant screens: the Marvel Studios logo. The chant, five years old now, a ritual: "NO-BO-DY! NO-BO-DY!"

KEVIN FEIGE (37) walks out to a standing ovation.

FEIGE
Five movies. Five promises kept. And today we're going to show you two more. Then we're going to show you something we've been building since 2006.

The roar is deafening.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Let's go to Asgard.

Lights down. THOR footage. A real Norwegian fjord at sunrise. A golden throne room carved into a mountain. Real armor. Real horses. Esther as THOR, in

silver and red with a crimson cape, walking out onto a balcony overlooking a city of gold.

A FROST GIANT, practical and enormous, charges across a frozen Icelandic glacier. Thor spins Mjolnir and HURLS it. The hammer blasts through the giant and returns to her hand. The hall screams.

Then Thor, in a desert in New Mexico, stripped of her powers, trying to lift Mjolnir from the crater. It won't move. She falls to her knees in the rain.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
Father. What have I become?

Black. THOR. MAY 6, 2011.

The hall erupts. KENNETH BRANAGH (49), TOM HIDDLESTON (29), and ESTHER SMILLEY (27) walk out to a thunderous standing ovation. Esther wears the crimson cape from the footage over a black dress.

BRANAGH
(into the mic)
Every shot you just saw, we did for real. That glacier is in Iceland. That fjord is in Norway. That rain in New Mexico was so cold I lost feeling in my toes. And Esther threw that hammer three hundred and twelve times.

ESTHER
Three hundred and thirteen. You forgot the one that hit the catering tent.

Laughter. Then a voice from the crowd, Priya: "SHE IS WORTHY!" The hall takes it up: "SHE IS WORTHY! SHE IS WORTHY!" Esther puts a hand over her heart.

CUT TO:

**INT. HALL H - STAGE - LATER**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010 - 3:30 P.M. PDT**

CAPTAIN AMERICA footage. Brooklyn, 1941, filmed on the actual cobblestones of DUMBO. A skinny Steve Rogers getting beaten in an alley and refusing to stay down. The Vita-Ray chamber. Steve emerging transformed. And then CAPTAIN AMERICA in his original 1941 Simon and Kirby costume, with the triangular shield, punching Adolf Hitler on a USO stage.

The hall LOSES IT. JOE JOHNSTON (60) and TYRESE AVERY walk out to a roar.

Feige stops in the middle of the stage and raises his hand.

FEIGE
One thing before Tyrese says anything. Today is July twenty-fourth.

(beat)
Captain America turns twenty-nine today.

The hall gasps and laughs. And then, spontaneously, six thousand five hundred people start singing.

CROWD
HAPPY BIRTHDAY TO YOU... HAPPY BIRTHDAY TO YOU...

Tyrese stands frozen at the center of the stage, completely overwhelmed. The pop star who has sung to eighty thousand people a night is being sung to. His eyes fill. He covers his face with both hands.

CROWD (CONT'D)
HAPPY BIRTHDAY, DEAR CAPTAIN... HAPPY BIRTHDAY TO YOU!

TYRESE
(into the mic, his voice cracking)
I've performed in front of a million people. Nobody ever sang to me before.

(beat)
My granddaddy would've loved this. Thank you.

CUT TO:

**INT. HALL H - STAGE - LATER**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010 - 4:00 P.M. PDT**

The lights dim completely. Silence. A single spotlight on Feige at center stage.

FEIGE
In September 1963, Stan Lee and Jack Kirby put five heroes on one cover. In March 1964, they found a sixth one frozen in the ice. And they called them...

(beat)
Well. You already know what they called them.

The crowd begins to rumble: "A-VEN-GERS..."

FEIGE (CONT'D)
First, the man who's going to bring them together. The writer and director of THE AVENGERS... Joss Whedon!

JOSS WHEDON (46) walks out, waving, to a roar from the geek faithful. He takes the microphone.

WHEDON
Hi. I'm the luckiest nerd alive. Kevin, can I do it?

FEIGE
Do it.

WHEDON
Okay. Ladies and gentlemen, the director of S.H.I.E.L.D... Nick Fury!

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (61) strides out in a long black leather coat and an eyepatch. The roar is enormous. He stops at center stage and points out at

the crowd.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON
I said I was putting a team together. You didn't believe me.

Laughter and cheers. Whedon continues, faster now, each name greeted by a bigger roar.

WHEDON
Agent Phil Coulson, Clark Gregg! And the god of mischief who's going to try to destroy them all... Loki, Tom Hiddleston!

CLARK GREGG (48) gives a crisp salute. Hiddleston bows deeply and theatrically, then blows a kiss. The hall boos and cheers him at the same time.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
And now, in the order they first appeared in AVENGERS #1... the founders.

(beat)
Ant-Man... David Tipton!

DAVID TIPTON (29) jogs out. A thousand people shout "ENHANCE!"

WHEDON (CONT'D)
The Wasp, the woman who named them... Elxa Bullock!

ELXA BULLOCK (29) walks out in gold, to a huge cheer.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
The strongest one there is. The Hulk... Amond Baker!

AMOND BAKER (28) bounds out and roars. The hall roars back. He throws two fists in the air.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
The God of Thunder... Esther Smilley!

Esther walks out, cape billowing, and the "SHE IS WORTHY" chant shakes the room.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
The man who started it all. Iron Man... Marc-Anthony Bullock!

MARC-ANTHONY walks out last of the founders. The sound is physically painful. He stops at the center of the stage, turns, and stands beside Esther.

And then Whedon raises his hand.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
And the man they found in the ice. Steve Rogers. Captain America... the birthday boy... Tyrese Avery!

Tyrese walks out holding the triangular shield prop over his head. The hall is a wall of sound. Six heroes stand in a line: Ant-Man, Wasp, Hulk, Thor, Iron Man, Cap. The cover of AVENGERS #1 and #4, come to life.

Fans in the front rows are sobbing openly. Gary has his hands over his mouth.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
(over the noise)
But Nick Fury doesn't build a team without backup. Two agents of S.H.I.E.L.D. The deadliest spy in the world... Black Widow, Harmony Divine!

HARMONY DIVINE (28) walks out in black, does a flawless backflip at center stage, and lands perfectly on the beat. The hall goes wild. Amond, in the line of Avengers, applauds louder than anyone.

WHEDON (CONT'D)
And one more. You've been guessing for months. Carnival kid. Trick shot. Never misses. Making her very first public appearance as Hawkeye...

(beat)
...Claire Barton. Arianna Cummings!

A beat of confused silence. Then a stage platform lowers from above the audience. On it stands ARIANNA CUMMINGS (27), in black and purple, a real recurve bow in her hand. She draws an arrow, aims across Hall H at a target on the far wall, and FIRES.

THUNK. Dead center.

She draws a second arrow and fires again. CRACK. It splits the first arrow straight down the middle.

Silence. Then Hall H detonates. A sound like an earthquake. People screaming, hugging strangers, standing on chairs.

Arianna steps off the platform onto the stage and joins the line beside Harmony. TEN heroes and agents stand together in front of six thousand five hundred screaming people.

CROWD
A-VEN-GERS! A-VEN-GERS! A-VEN-GERS!

Marc-Anthony, at the center of the line, glances to his left. Esther, beside him, is crying and laughing. Without thinking, she reaches over and grabs his hand. Just for a second. Then lets go.

Six thousand five hundred people don't notice. Nine people on that stage do. And one man, standing at the back of Hall H behind the press riser, notices most of all.

DESMOND SMILLEY.

CUT TO:

**INT. HALL H - Q AND A - CONTINUOUS**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010 - 4:20 P.M. PDT**

At the audience mic: Priya, of course. Five years in a row.

PRIYA
Hi, Kevin. Hi, Joss. Hi, everyone. I have a very nerdy question.

FEIGE
My favorite kind. And my favorite fan.

PRIYA
Hawkeye isn't a founding Avenger. She joins in AVENGERS #16, with Quicksilver and the Scarlet Witch, when Cap takes over the team. "Cap's Kooky Quartet." So if Claire's an agent in THIS movie...

(beat, shaking)
...are you already planning the NEXT one?

Whedon and Feige look at each other. Feige leans into his mic.

FEIGE
Priya, you've been asking me questions in this room for four years. Have I ever answered one?

PRIYA
No.

FEIGE
Read AVENGERS #16.

The hall erupts again. Priya stumbles back from the mic into Darnell, screaming. Next at the mic: a nervous TEENAGE BOY (13) in a homemade Hulk costume.

TEENAGE BOY
This is for Amond. In AVENGERS #4, they find Captain America frozen. Is he going to be frozen in the movie?

Amond leans into his mic, excited.

AMOND
Oh, buddy, great question. So at the end of the Cap movie, Steve crashes the plane into the Arctic, and then in the Avengers, the team finds him in the...

Tyrese, standing beside him, calmly places his entire hand over Amond's mouth. The hall SCREAMS with laughter.

TYRESE
(into his own mic, hand still on Amond's mouth)
He doesn't know what he's talking about. He's the Hulk. He doesn't read.

AMOND
(muffled, through Tyrese's hand)
...mmmph... ice...

Whedon is doubled over. Feige has his face in his hands. Lenora, in the wings, is visibly drafting a memo.

CUT TO:

**MONTAGE - THE AVENGERS ASSEMBLE ONLINE**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 24 - SUNDAY, JULY 25, 2010**

**YOUTUBE.COM - "THE AVENGERS CAST ASSEMBLES - HALL H 2010 (FULL LINEUP + HAWKEYE ARROW SPLIT)" - uploaded by hallh_bootleg_10 - 6,882,104 views**

Top comment - ThorOdinson4Ever: this is the greatest 4 minutes in comic con history. the arrow split. the birthday song. tyrese covering amonds mouth. I'M NOT OKAY

**SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "THE AVENGERS ARE ASSEMBLED - HALL H 2010" (Page 1 of 812)**

**ShellHead1963 (Jul 24, 4:45 PM)**
I was in Hall H. I saw ten heroes on one stage. I'm 44 years old and I cried so hard a Stormtrooper offered me a tissue. Apology #211: I said in 2006 this could never happen. It happened.

**NoNerfsPlz (Jul 24, 4:52 PM)**
"READ AVENGERS #16." That's Cap, Hawkeye, Quicksilver and Scarlet Witch. They're planning the sequel. Hawkeye is the first piece. I asked the question. I'm the question girl. It's my legacy.

**Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Jul 24, 5:01 PM)**
Arianna Cummings split an arrow with another arrow LIVE in Hall H. Who IS she? Off-Broadway actress. Critics call her the best actress in New York. Never had a breakthrough. She has one now.

**WarMachineRox (Jul 24, 5:10 PM)**
Amond almost said "ice." Tyrese put his whole hand over his mouth. On stage. In front of 6500 people. This is my favorite cast in movie history.

**Repulsor_Ray (Jul 24, 5:30 PM)**
did everyone see esther grab marc-anthony's hand during the chant??? for like one second??? there's a GIF

**Mjolnir_Worthy (Jul 24, 5:44 PM)**
The hand grab GIF has 40,000 reblogs on Tumblr. Hollywood's Romeo and Juliet are holding hands in Hall H in front of her own father.

**TUMBLR - "STARKTHOR" TAG - SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010**

**[GIF: Esther Smilley, tearful, reaching for Marc-Anthony Bullock's hand during the Avengers chant. One second. She lets go.]**

*Caption: "she held his hand for ONE (1) second and then let go like she remembered her father was in the building." - 52,118 notes*

**TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010**

**#Avengers - #HallH - Arianna Cummings - #HappyBirthdayCap - Joss Whedon - Hawkeye - #Starkthor**

**TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE**

**ariannacummings:** 2 years ago i had 4 rejection letters taped to my mirror. today i split an arrow in hall h. if you're still waiting for your break: keep shooting. #Hawkeye 6:10 PM Jul 24th from web

**tyreseavery:** 6500 people sang me happy birthday today. i've never cried on stage before. thank you. also i'm sorry i put my hand over @amondbaker's mouth. (i'm not sorry) 7:02 PM Jul 24th from web

**amondbaker:** i was going to say "nice." the avengers find him and say "nice." that's all. nobody panic 7:15 PM Jul 24th from web

CUT TO:

**INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - BACKSTAGE CORRIDOR - HALL H - DAY**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010 - 4:50 P.M. PDT**

A long gray concrete corridor behind Hall H. Marvel staff with radios. Cast members heading toward the press room in clusters. Marc-Anthony is alone for a moment, refilling a water bottle at a cooler.

Footsteps. He turns. DESMOND SMILLEY (52) stands in the corridor, ten feet away. Nobody else is around.

DESMOND
Mr. Bullock.

MARC-ANTHONY
(setting down the water, polite)
Mr. Smilley.

Desmond walks closer. Very calm. Very quiet.

DESMOND
I'm going to say this once. Stay away from my daughter.

A long beat. Marc-Anthony doesn't step back.

MARC-ANTHONY
With respect, sir. That isn't up to me. And it isn't up to you.

DESMOND
Everything about my daughter is up to me.

MARC-ANTHONY
She's twenty-seven years old, Mr. Smilley. She's the God of Thunder. She learned Shakespeare from your father in a garage at midnight and lifted a hammer in front of six thousand people. Nothing about her is up to anybody but her.

Desmond's eyes flash.

DESMOND
Your family has taken everything from mine. Everything. My grandfather's savings. My father's company. My name in PREMIERE. My clients. My son's role. And now you want...

MARC-ANTHONY
(quietly, not unkindly)
I don't want to take anything from you, sir. I've never wanted that.

(beat)
I grew up watching you on SOUTHERN HEAT, with the sound turned down so my mom wouldn't hear. You were the coolest man on television. I wanted to be you. I'm not your enemy. I never was.

Desmond stares at him. For a moment, something flickers across his face: confusion, almost. Nobody from that family has ever spoken to him like this.

DESMOND
(hoarse)
You don't know anything about what my family has been through.

MARC-ANTHONY
You're right. I don't. Maybe you could tell me someday.

A long, strange silence in the empty corridor. Then, from around the corner, a Marvel publicist calls: "Marc! Press room, two minutes!"

Desmond steps back. Straightens his jacket. The mask returns.

DESMOND
This isn't over.

MARC-ANTHONY
No, sir. I don't think it is.

Desmond turns and walks away down the corridor. Marc-Anthony watches him go. Then he picks up his water bottle. His hand is shaking slightly.

At the far end of the corridor, half hidden behind a stack of equipment cases, Esther has seen and heard every word. She steps back out of sight before either of them notices.

CUT TO:

**INT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - SERVICE STAIRWELL - NIGHT**

**SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 24, 2010 - 11:45 P.M. PDT**

The same concrete stairwell as last year. Between the 18th and 19th floors. Marc-Anthony comes down the stairs from the 20th floor. Esther is already sitting there, waiting, shoes off, still wearing Thor's crimson cape over her T-shirt.

MARC-ANTHONY
You heard.

ESTHER
Every word.

He sits on the step below her.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm sorry. I didn't mean to make it worse.

ESTHER
You told my father you wanted to be him when you were little.

MARC-ANTHONY
It was true.

ESTHER
Nobody's said anything kind to my father in thirty years without wanting something. You said it while he was threatening you.

(beat)
I watched his face. He didn't know what to do with it.

A pause.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
My mother knows. I showed her the hospital pictures. She said she won't help him stop me.

MARC-ANTHONY
(surprised)
Your mother?

ESTHER
She wants to meet you. Properly. She wants to see if you're as handsome as you are in the paper-crown pictures.

MARC-ANTHONY
(laughing despite himself)
My mother knows too. She said, and I quote, "You could do much worse."

Esther laughs, a real laugh that echoes up the stairwell. She covers her mouth.

ESTHER
Natasha Bullock said that?

MARC-ANTHONY
On Mother's Day. Over a mimosa.

They laugh together. Then it fades. They look at each other.

ESTHER
I grabbed your hand on stage.

MARC-ANTHONY
I noticed.

ESTHER
So did fifty thousand people on Tumblr.

MARC-ANTHONY
Fifty-two thousand. I checked.

A long, quiet moment.

ESTHER
(very softly)
London's in eight months.

MARC-ANTHONY
Eight months.

ESTHER
Ask me then.

MARC-ANTHONY
(smiling)
I've been asking you since 1994, Esther.

ESTHER
(a beat, then, so quietly he almost doesn't hear it)
I know. I've been saying yes since 1994. I just haven't said it out loud.

Marc-Anthony goes completely still. Esther stands, gathers her shoes and her cape, and stops on the step above him. She leans down and kisses the top of his head. Just once. Then she slips through the eighteenth-floor door and is gone.

Marc-Anthony sits alone in the stairwell, staring at the door. Footsteps below. The same SECURITY GUARD (51) from last year comes around the landing with his flashlight. He stops. Looks at Marc-Anthony. Looks at the door.

SECURITY GUARD
Getting your steps in, Mr. Stark?

MARC-ANTHONY
(dazed, smiling)
Every year, sir.

SECURITY GUARD
(nodding slowly, a small smile)
Same time next year, then.

FADE OUT.

**MONDAY HEADLINES**

**SUPER: MONDAY, JULY 26, 2010**

**VARIETY - MON JULY 26, 2010**

**MARVEL ASSEMBLES 'AVENGERS' IN HALL H; WHEDON TO DIRECT, CUMMINGS IS HAWKEYE**

*Ten-person lineup unveiled for May 2012 release; founding-five structure follows the 1963 comic. Hawkeye reveal hints at a planned sequel. Production begins spring 2011, on location in New York City.*

**THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MON JULY 26, 2010**

**THE MOST AMBITIOUS PLAN IN HOLLYWOOD HISTORY**

*Six films, six heroes, one team. Rivals who called Marvel "insane" in 2007 now quietly study its playbook. "They built an entire universe in five years," says one studio chief. "We can't even build a sequel."*

**ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - COVER (Issue of Aug. 6, 2010)**

**EARTH'S MIGHTIEST HEROES**

*Ten heroes. Two feuding families. One arrow, split in half. Inside the Hall H moment that changed movies forever.*

**US WEEKLY - (Issue of Aug. 9, 2010)**

**THE HAND HOLD! Esther & Marc-Anthony's One-Second Romance - And Her Father Was WATCHING**

**JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Issue of Aug. 9, 2010)**

**Eight Black Heroes on One Stage**

*Iron Man, the Hulk, the Wasp, Thor, Captain America, Black Widow, Hawkeye, and Nick Fury. Hollywood has never seen anything like it. Plus: sources say Desmond Smilley and Natasha Bullock met privately at the Polo Lounge last week. Neither will say what was discussed.*

FADE OUT.

**END OF CHAPTER TWELVE**